

# **Introduction to Business Communication**

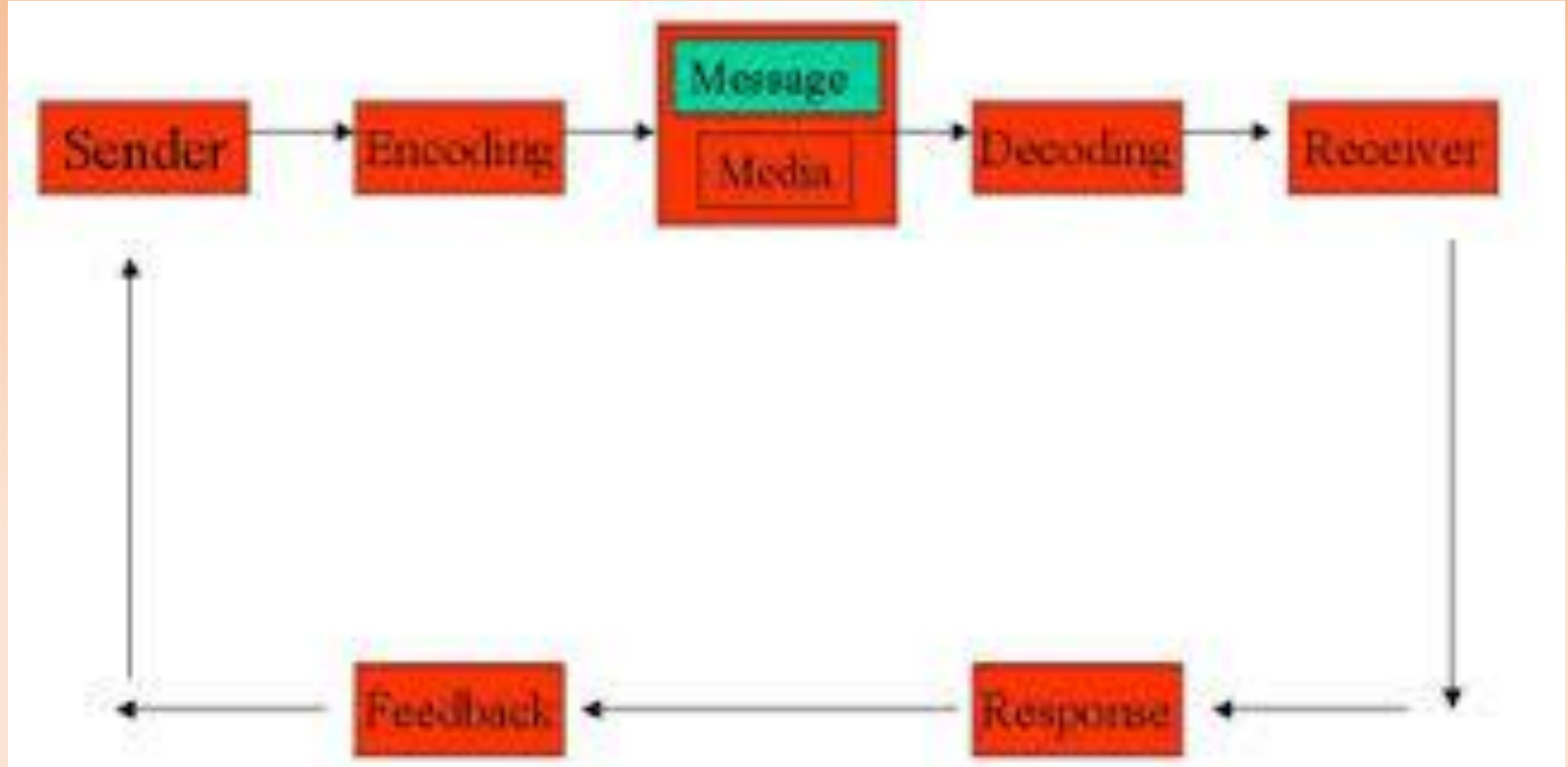
Definition, Importance, Purpose, Process, Elements & Models

Department of Communication

# Meaning of communication

- The word “communication” is derived from the Latin word ‘communicare’ that means to impart, to participate, to share or to make common.
- It is a process of exchange of facts, ideas, opinions from one individual or organization to another. Meaning and understanding is shared with one another.
- Communication is the process of creating, interpreting, and negotiating meaning. Communication can be verbal, nonverbal, or textual. It can be aural, visual, or even physical. Although communication occurs in a variety of different ways, it is always a learned behaviour. While most human beings are born with the physical abilities to speak, to hear, to see, and so on, people must learn to communicate through codes, symbols, and systems of language. In this way, communication is a collective practice in which people use symbols to generate and interpret meaning.

# Process of communication and elements



# Types of communication

Communication can be classified into several categories-

- On the basis of **Organizational structure**-
  - Formal and informal
- On the basis of **methods/media used or expression**-
  - Written oral
  - Gestural
- On the basis of **flow of direction**-
  - Upward
  - Downward
  - Horizontal/lateral
  - Diagonal

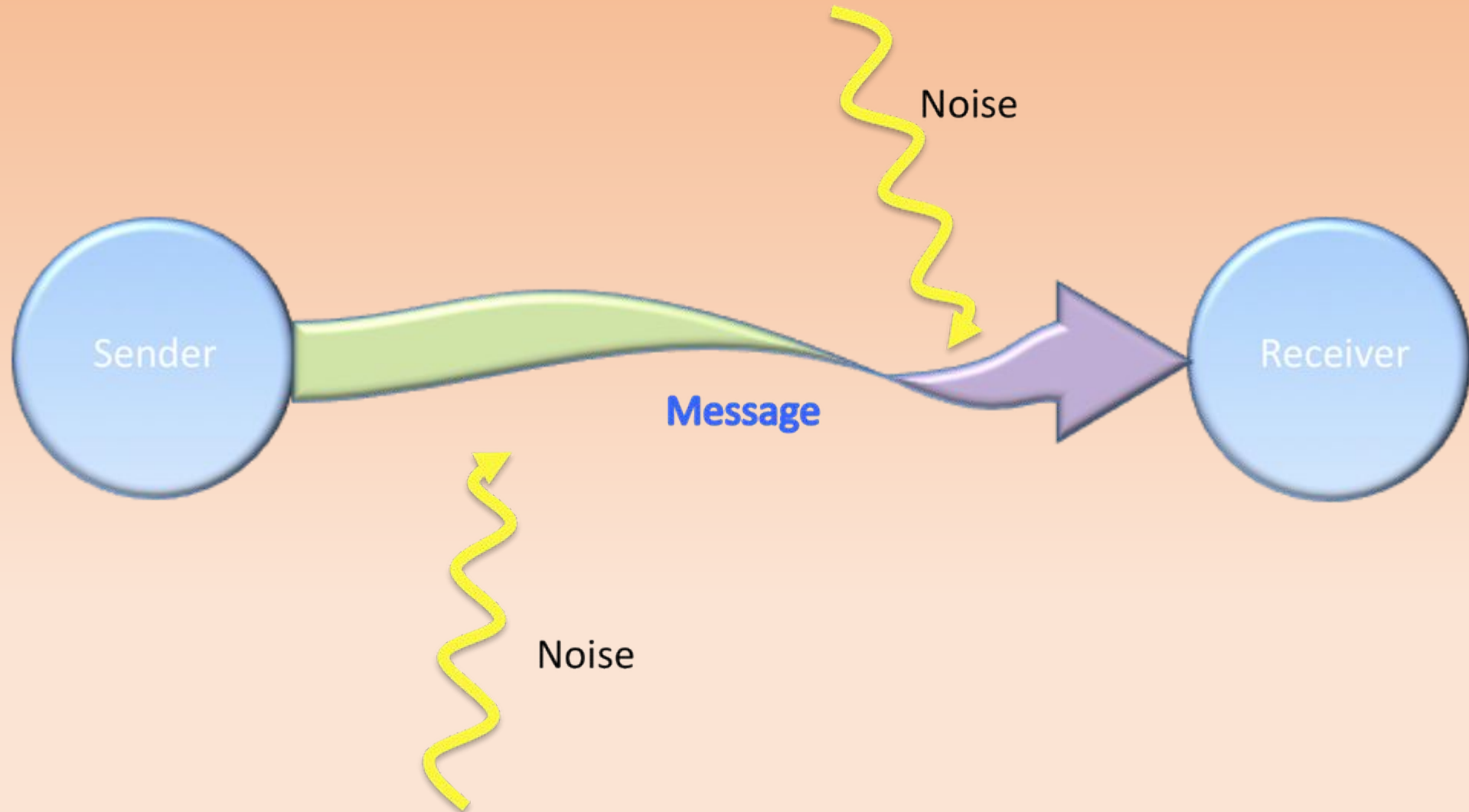
# Models of communication

- In order to explain the social process of communication, scholars have developed several models. The three most well known models for communication are
  - Linear,
  - Interactional, and
  - Transactional

# Linear model

- Originally developed by Shannon and Weaver in 1948, this model describes communication as a linear process. This model describes how a sender, or speaker, transmits a message to a receiver, or listener. More specifically, the *sender* is the source of the message. A *message* may consist of the sounds, words, or behaviours in a communication interaction. The message itself is transmitted through a *channel*, the pathway or route for communication, to a *receiver*, who is the target or recipient of the message. There may be obstacles in the communication process, or noise. *Noise* refers to any interference in the channel or distortion of the message. This is a fairly simple model in which a message is simply passed from sender to receiver.
- Limitations:
  - 1. Communication in action is more dynamic than the linear model suggests. In action, communication involves a give and take between senders and receivers in which listeners are not simply passive receptacles for a sender's message.
  - 2. It provides only one channel for only one message which implies that messages themselves are clear-cut with a distinct beginning and a distinct end. However, communication is rarely, if ever, as neat and tidy as a linear model would suggest.

# Linear

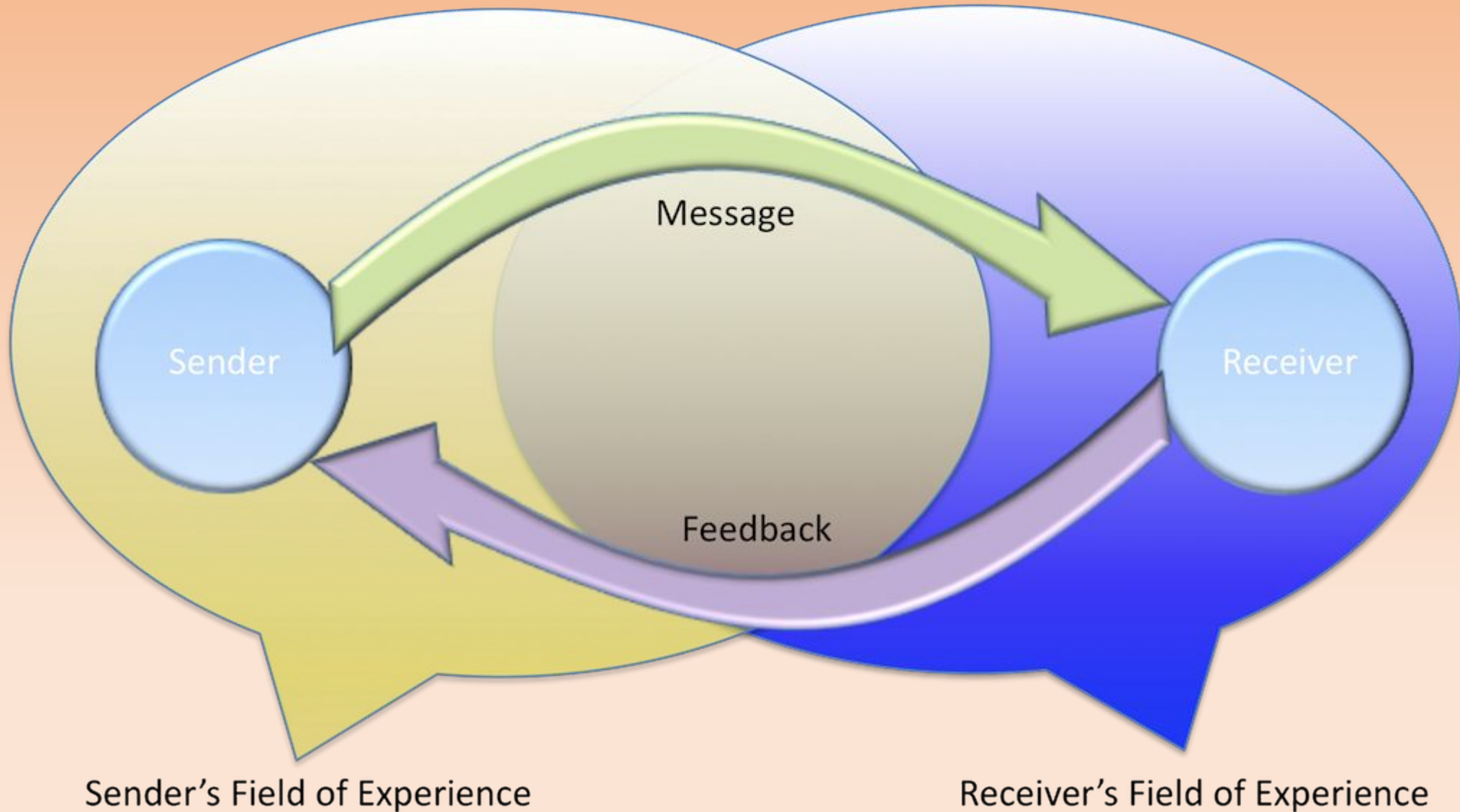


# Interactional model

- In the move to a more dynamic view of communication, interactional models follow two channels in which communication and feedback flow between sender and receiver. *Feedback* is simply a response that a receiver gives to a sender. Feedback can be verbal (i.e. “yes”) or nonverbal (i.e. a nod or smile). Most importantly, feedback indicates comprehension. It can help senders know if their message was received and understood. By focusing on flow and feedback, interactional models view communication as an ongoing process.
- The final feature of this model is the field of experience. The *field of experience* refers to how environment, experiences, culture, and even heredity can influence how a sender constructs a message. Keep in mind that each person brings a unique field of experience to an interaction. Likewise, each communication interaction is unique.
- While the interactional model is more dynamic than the linear model, it still contains some limitations. For instance, this model implies that while people can be both senders and receivers, they cannot do so simultaneously. In live communication, roles are not quite so clear-cut and in fact are much more fluid.



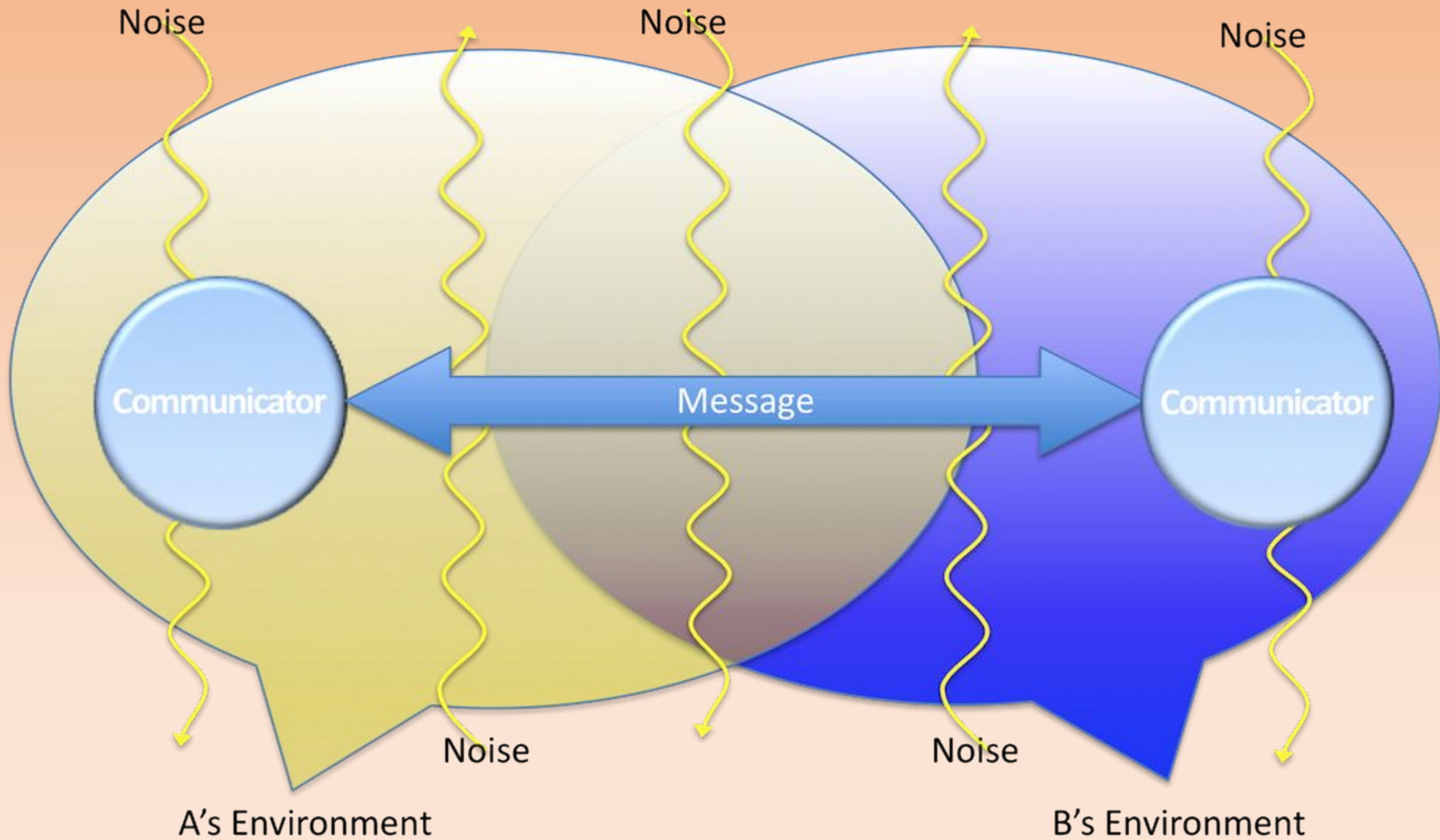
# Interactive



# Transactional model

- The transactional is the most dynamic of communication models. One notable feature of this model is the move from referring to people as senders and receivers to referring to people as *communicators*. This implies that communication is achieved as people both send and receive messages. Fundamentally, this model views communication as a transaction. In other words, communication is a cooperative action in which communicators co-create the process, outcome and effectiveness of the interaction. Unlike the linear model in which meaning is sent from one person to another, also unlike the interactional model in which understanding is achieved through feedback, people create shared meaning in a more dynamic process in the transactional model.
- This model also places more emphasis on the field of experience. While each communicator has a unique field of experience, they must also inhabit a shared field of experience. In other words, communicators must share at least some degree of overlap in culture, language, or environment if people are to communicate at all. This model also recognizes that messages will influence the responses, or subsequent messages, produced in the communication interaction. This means that messages do not stand alone, but instead are interrelated. The principle of interrelation states that messages are connected to and build upon one another. The transactional model forms the basis for much communication theory because (1) people are viewed as dynamic communicators rather than simple senders or receivers, (2) there must be some overlap in fields of experience in order to build shared meaning, and (3) messages are interdependent.

# Transactional



# Verbal & Non-verbal Communication

# Meaning of verbal and non-verbal

- Verbal- using words for exchanging of meaning, encoding content into messages.

Forms of verbal- oral and written forms which are highly structured and follow rules of grammar and syntax.

- Non-verbal-uses symbols to convey meaning and create understanding.

Forms of non-verbal- symbols which are highly unstructured and have fluid meaning and changes with the context.

# Types of verbal and non-verbal

## a) Verbal

- Oral
- Written

## b) Non-verbal

- KOPPACT

# Verbal communication- ORAL

Oral communication types:

- Face-to-face conversation
- Interviews
- Meetings and discussions
- Presentations, talks, and conferences
- Telephonic conversations

# Advantages of oral communication:

- Clarifications are much faster
- Feedback is immediate
- Adds personal touch
- Can be effective with supporting gestures
- Most effective for persuasion and resolving conflicts
- Sensitive and emotionally charged messages are best delivered orally
- Simple form that saves time and money
- Exhibits fluidity, flexibility and transparency of exchange



# Disadvantages of oral communication

- Complex and lengthy messages cannot be sent orally
- No documentation for future reference
- Nonverbal factors may negate oral communication
- Limited human memory allows limited retention
- It lacks formality for business communication and accountability is limited
- Requires great effort and attentiveness to succeed
- Not legally valid

# WRITTEN Communication

Examples of written communication in organizations:

- Business letters and emails
- Inter office memorandum
- Facsimiles
- Notice and circular
- Agenda and minutes
- Reports and proposals
- Manuals and brochures
- Contracts and agreements

# Advantages of written communication

- Suitable for lengthy messages
- Ready reference: provides recall easily
- Legal defense: safeguard against challenges and offences
- Promotes uniformity: same message goes out in clear terms
- Mass access: gives access to larger audiences
- Unambiguous and permanent

# Disadvantages of written communication

- Limited to literate people
- Time consuming as it includes planning and drafting time
- Needs good grasp of formal language for proper expression
- Expensive in terms of paper used, equipment needed and transmission cost
- Lacks immediate feedback.

# NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION

- Non-verbal communication includes exchange of messages with the use of signs and symbols. It is context dominated and culture specific.
- According to Mehrabian words convey 7% meaning, 38% by paralinguistics and 55% through gestures. So, 93% of meaning of oral communication is conveyed through non-verbal means.
- If there is any incongruity between verbal and non-verbal messages, understanding is created on the basis of non-verbal messages.

# Importance of non-verbal communication

- For professional purpose nonverbal communication plays a crucial role in creating meanings and driving home points.
- Non verbal communication is used to repeat, accentuate, complement, contradict or substitute verbal communication.
- It involves sending and receiving messages through gestures, body language, posture, facial expression, eye contact clothing, appearance, managing time, symbols etc
- In presentations, use of nonverbal gestures reinforces and enhances meaning. It can create and increase trust and add interest.
- Another aspect of nonverbal is dependent on spoken words called paralanguage such as voice quality, intonation, stress, rhythm etc
- In meetings and discussions nonverbal messages emphasize points and gain attention.

# Characteristics of non-verbal

- Less prone to manipulation as it exists in the subconscious level.
- It is more factual/true compared to verbal communication
- Non-verbal interpretation can be misinterpreted as it is culture specific
- May complement or contradict verbal communication

# Functions of nonverbal

- Repeating /duplicating messages
- Substituting/replacing verbal messages
- Complementing/reinforcing verbal messages
- Emphasizing verbal messages
- Regulating or controlling meaning of verbal messages
- Contradicting verbal messages intentionally or unintentionally



# KOPPACT

- Kinesics
- Oculistics
- Paralinguistics
- Proxemics
- Artifactics
- Chronemics
- Tactilics/Haptics

# Kinesics

- Kinesics, also referred to as body language, is the unspoken communication that goes on in every face-to-face communication. It reveals true emotions and attitudes in communicators and indicates the way messages are received and understood. Almost 60% of a message is communicated through kinesics.
- It includes gestures, postures, facial expression, eye-contact etc.

# Gesture- types and meaning

Gestures are movements of the head and hands.

- Emblems: culturally defined hand movements that translate into simple words.

E.g.: pointing finger at wrist- what is the time? Affirmative or negative replies, evaluate others and clarify meaning.

- Illustrators: gestures that describe or indicate size, shape, distance or movement. These are used extensively during presentations to enhance and clarify meaning
- Adapters: these are odd, repetitive nervous mannerisms that often reveal a state of mind or emotion. They are used to relieve tension, and are usually unconsciously used.

# Postures

- Postures are the way we sit or stand. They indicate openness and willingness to communicate.

# OCULESICS

It is the language of the eye. This includes eye contact or avoidance of eye contact, eye movement, and eye contractions. These movements are mostly involuntary but can also be accentuated to create impact.

Functions of eye contact:

- Gaze:

1. To control, monitor and regulate
2. To express and understand

- Mutual gaze:

1. To hold attention and establish contact
2. To show respect and interest

Meanings of gaze aversion (looking away during interaction)

1. Signals disinterest in person or topic
2. Perceived as emotional states of guilt, fear, shame or inferiority

# PARALINGUISTICS/ PARALANGUAGE

- These are nonverbal vocal messages carried through voice quality, pitch, tone, speed, and clarity. They can reinforce or negate a message. They refer to all vocally produced sound that do not have linguistic communication.
- The voice is an extraordinary instrument that communicates messages beyond words. The voice reveals mental states, emotions, gender, nationality, age, educational levels, and relationships. Paralanguage is an important part of presentations and conversations, both face-to-face and telephonic.
- Tone is the physical level at which voice is transmitted. It is used to convey attitude and can be done consciously as well as unconsciously.
- Voice inflection is the way the voice is changed to emphasize key words or identify the purpose of statements.
- Pitch is a measure of the high or low of voice throw. Pitch varies according to biological functions and emotions. This happens automatically. It can also be changed deliberately to change, add to, or move away from an exchange.

# PROXEMICS

Language of space and proximity

- Hall's four zones: These zones create a comfortable ambience for communication. They also represent the relationship between communicators. They refer to the space surrounding an individual that is held to be owned.
- Zone 1: intimate zone-0-10 inches. Indicates very close or intimate relationships and impacts behavior. Unauthorized intrusion into this space is viewed as harassment and intimidation.
- Zone 2: personal zone: 12 inches to 4 feet. This is the distance allotted for friends and colleagues. It is also used for group discussions and meetings. Intrusion into personal space is considered as threatening and dominating behavior.
- Zone 3: social zone: 4 feet to 12 feet. This space is reserved for new acquaintances, associates, newly formed teams and strangers.
- Zone 4: Public space:12 feet and beyond. This is for public speaking and formal presentations.

# Territoriality

Territorial space: this refers to the area or territory within which authority is established. It is the space that individuals are accustomed to occupy or are given to them individually or in groups.

- Primary territory: (area of comfort, well protected (office cubicle or chamber)
- Secondary territory: neutral areas open to occupation (library, restaurants etc)
- Interaction territory: space where groups meet for interaction (meeting or conference rooms)
- Public territory: open to everyone

## **Types of territorial encroachment**

1. Violation: unwarranted use of another's territory (enter without permission)
2. Invasion: entering the territory changes meaning (Entering a discussion or meeting without invitation)
3. Contamination: rendering an territory impure(smoking in non smoking area)



# ARTIFACTICS

- Language of accessories, dress and all objects carried or used by individuals and groups. These create impressions and send out messages regarding socio-economic status, educational level, personality type, culture and mood.
- They dictate how others interact or react as they represent the preferences and essence of individuals.

# CHRONEMICS

- **Chronemics** is the language of time. The way time is used and allotted reveals attitudes and interests as well as skill and efficiency. It also presents ideas about respect and consideration towards others. Time is culturally viewed as monochromatic and polychromatic.
- **Monochromatic time** considers time to be mechanically divided according to the movement of the clock. People who consider time to be monochromatic adhere to schedules strictly, have definite time allocation for tasks and are very punctual. They take tardiness and loss of time very seriously. Such people meet deadlines and are serious about time commitments. Their time is organized, fully utilized, and accounted for their focus on tasks and completion of tasks.
- **Polychromatic time** considers time as a fluid and flowing entity. People who consider time to be polychromatic work at multiple tasks simultaneously, and are flexible about punctuality and deadlines. They are relationship focused and are willing to spend time to build and maintain relationships.

# TACTILICS/ HAPTICS

- This refers to the language of touch. Haptics provides information regarding surface and texture and is also a component of interpersonal communication.
- Touch is categorized as playful, controlling, ritualistic, task related and unintentional. It is the first sense to be developed in humans and instinctively tells the receiver the intention of the person who touches. The meaning of touch is determined by relationship, time and place, cultural norms, area of touch, and intention. The messages conveyed through touch range from positive emotions such as support, inclusion, affection, and interest, to gaining compliance, controlling, gaining attention, and intimidating.

# Haslin's interpretation

- Functional/professional: touch related to professional needs and requirements. This includes handshakes, brief brush of fingers when objects are handed over
- Social: touch related to maintaining social norms such as touching of cheeks, handshakes, using hand to guide body during dances for example.
- Friendship: linking arms, shoulder embrace, and mock attacks to indicate friendship
- Intimate: close embraces, kissing, caressing, body support

# **Barriers of Communication**

# What are communication barriers?

The word barrier means an obstacle, a hindrance or simply a problem that comes in a way of transmission of a message and blocks the process, either completely or partially.

These barriers can lead to misunderstandings and decreased productivity. They can stem from various sources, including physical limitations, differences in

perception, emotional states, cultural and language variations, and even the way information is presented.

## **1. Physical or Environmental Barriers**

Physical barriers to communication are environmental or material obstacles that interfere with the effective transmission or reception of a message. These can include noise, distance, poor lighting, or technical difficulties, all of which can

hinder clear and timely communication.

a. **Noise** - The noise created by external factors like traffic, playing of loud music, trains and airplanes, or by crowds of people, affects our communication.

b. **Time & distance** - Time becomes a physical barrier when people have to communicate across different time zones in different countries. The



physical distance between people who need to communicate can also cause problems because it does not allow oral or face-to-face communication.

c. **Defects in communication system** – Mechanical problems and defects in instruments of communication also create physical barriers, as in a faulty fax machine or typewriter. Similarly, a computer that hangs, or a dead telephone line can

lead to non-transmission of messages. eg. No range in mobile, technical problem in mic or speakers.

d. **Wrong selection of medium** – The sender selects the medium which is not familiar to the receiver.

e. **Physiological defects** like stammering, hearing defects, mumbling while speaking etc.

## **Language or Semantic barriers:**

Language or Semantic barriers: Language is the main medium of communication and words are its tools.

Language proves to be a barrier at different levels, such as semantic (meaning), syntactic (grammar), phonological (pronunciation, intonation, pitch etc.) and finally linguistic (across languages). Thus, language barriers can arise in different ways:

a. **Jargon or unfamiliar terminology** - There are some special terms or technical words used by people belonging to a certain group or field of work such as doctors, lawyers, computer software engineers or college students. They use words which are their own, specialised jargon which cannot be understood by anyone outside their group.

b. **Difference in language** – Unfamiliar language becomes a barrier when people do not know each other's language. This barrier can be overcome by using a common medium of communication, as in a classroom. Translation is also an important way of overcoming this barrier.

c. **Words are of two kinds: extensional and intentional words.** Extensional words are clear in

their meaning and therefore do not create barriers – such as words like boy, chair, garden etc. Intentional words are words that describe and they can be understood differently by different people, according to the meaning that a person gives to the word. Thus good, bad, beautiful are intentional words, and a simple sentence like she is a good girl can create confusion because the meaning of the word ‘good’ is unclear.

d. Sometimes, the same word is used in different contexts, giving rise to totally different meanings. A word like hard, for example can be used in different ways: hard chair, hard-hearted, having a hard time – all these use the same word but the meanings are different.

e. Barriers can be created when we come across words, which have the same sound when

pronounced, but which mean very different things.

Examples: words like fair and fare; see and sea; principle and principal.



## **Socio-cultural barriers:**

Mary Allen Guffey defines communication as ,”the complex system of values, traits, morals and customs shared by a society.”

Cultural diversity within a country, and cultural differences between people from different countries, are a major cause of barriers. This is because people are conditioned by their cultures, and they

develop certain habits of working, communicating, eating, dressing etc., according to their cultural conditioning. They find it difficult to get through to people who come from an alien culture, and who have different habits. A simple thing like a greeting to welcome a person is vastly different in India from a greeting in, for example, an Arab country, or in Japan. Food and dress habits of a different culture

can make a person uncomfortable. Concepts of space and time are also different across cultures; for example, Indians are a bit casual regarding time whereas Japanese are punctual.

## **Psychological barriers:**

Psyche means mind. Psychological barriers are created in the mind. Communication is a mental activity and its aim is to create understanding. But the human mind is complex and not all communication can result in understanding. There are several kinds of psychological barriers which can come in the way of understanding.

(a) **Emotions:** Emotions are among the most common psychological barriers to communication. The emotion may be connected to the communication received or it may be present in the sender's or receiver's mind, even before the communication takes place. In both cases, it acts as a barrier. Emotions can be positive, like happiness and joy, or negative, like fear, anger, mistrust etc.

Both positive and negative emotions act as barriers, if they are not kept in check.

(b) **Prejudice:** A prejudice is an opinion held by a person for which there is no rational basis or valid reason. It can be against something or someone, or in favour of it, but it becomes a barrier to a meaningful communication.

Prejudices are based on ignorance and lack of information, e.g., prejudices about certain communities or groups of people.

(c) **Halo effect:** Sometimes our reactions to people are not balanced or objective; they are of an extreme nature. Either we like a person so much that we can find no shortcomings in her/him, or we dislike someone so much that we can see nothing good in her/him. In both cases, we commit errors of judgment and fail to understand the person.

(d) **Self-image or different perceptions:** Every person has in her/his mind a certain image of herself/himself. S/he thinks of herself/himself in a certain way. This is their perception of themselves, their self-image. One's self-image is the product of one's heredity, one's environment and one's experiences, and thus every person's self-image is unique and different from the others. Self-image can create a barrier because we accept communication



which is compatible with our self-image. We avoid or reject communication, which goes against our perception of ourselves.

(e) **Closed Mind:** A closed mind is one which refuses to accept an idea or opinion on a subject, because it is different from their idea. Such persons form their opinion on a subject, and then refuse to listen to anyone who has something different to say about it. A closed mind may be the result of some past experience or just habit. It is very difficult to remove this psychological barrier.

(f) **Inattentiveness and Impatience:** Sometimes the receiver may not pay attention to the sender's message, or he may be too impatient to hear the message fully and properly. Such barriers are common in oral communication.

(g) **Status:** Status refers to rank or position. It could be economic, social or professional status. In any organisation, hierarchy creates differences in rank, and this is a normal situation. Thus, status by itself does not cause barriers; but when a person becomes too conscious of one's status, whether high or low, then status becomes a barrier. For instance, in a business organisation, a senior executive who is unduly conscious of their seniority will not

communicate properly with their juniors, and will refrain from giving them the required information. Similarly, if a junior is acutely conscious of one's junior status, they will avoid communicating with the seniors, even when it is necessary.

(h) **Premature evaluation:** Premature evaluation, as a psychological barrier, occurs when a receiver forms a judgment about a message before the sender has fully delivered it. This can significantly hinder effective communication by causing misunderstandings and biases. It often stems from preconceived notions, a lack of attention, or a tendency to jump to conclusions.

## Ways to overcome **Physical Barriers**:

Physical barriers are comparatively easier to overcome. The use of loudspeakers and microphones can remove the barriers of noise and distance in crowded places like railway stations. Traffic signals and non-verbal gestures of the traffic policeman remove physical barriers on the roads. Technological advancement has helped in reducing the communication gap arising due to time and

distance. One must try to make an alternative arrangement, should the technological instruments fail.



## Ways to overcome Semantic Barriers:

Language or Semantic Barriers can be overcome if the sender and the receiver choose a language which both of them understand very well. Help from a translator or an interpreter also helps in overcoming the language barrier. Exposure to the target language and training oneself in the

acquisition of skills of the given language too help in overcoming the language barrier. Language barriers can be avoided by careful study and accurate use of language. Clarity should be the main objective when using language. Jargons should be avoided.

## **Ways to overcome Socio-Cultural Barriers:**

Socio-cultural barriers are difficult to overcome, as they are difficult to identify and even more difficult to address. Even these can be avoided or reduced by adopting a flexible and open-minded attitude. The ultimate aim is to build bridges of understanding between people – that is the main aim of communication.

## Overcoming psychological barriers:

1. Adopt flexible and open-minded attitude

2. Training of listening skills

3. Exposure to different environment, views will help to broaden outlook

4. Listening with empathy helps in making oneself more adapting to others' perceptions.

# Interpersonal Communication:

Interpersonal communication is the two-way process of exchanging information, ideas, and feelings between two or more people using verbal and non-verbal cues. It forms the basis of personal and professional relationships, involving activities like conversations, meetings, and digital exchanges, and relies on active listening and understanding both what is said and how it is conveyed through tone, body language, and facial expressions.

# Key Characteristics

- **Interactivity:** Unlike mass communication, it involves a timely and reciprocal exchange, making it a collaborative process.
- **Relational:** It is focused on building and sustaining relationships, as opposed to impersonal, transactional interactions.
- **Verbal and Non-Verbal:** Communication is conveyed not only through words but also through non-verbal signals like body language, facial expressions, and tone of voice.

# Procedure:

- **Sending and Receiving:** One or more individuals send messages and signals to each other.
- **Encoding and Decoding:** Senders encode their ideas into messages, and receivers decode these messages.
- **Feedback:** The receiver provides feedback, which is then processed by the sender, creating a continuous loop of interaction.

# Types of Interpersonal Communication:

- **Verbal Communication:** The use of words in spoken or written form to convey messages.
- **Non-Verbal Communication:** The use of body language, facial expressions, gestures, and tone of voice.
- **Listening:** Actively paying attention to and understanding what others are communicating, which goes beyond simply hearing.
- **Written Communication:** Using text or other written forms to exchange messages, such as emails or messages.



# Importance:

- **Workplace Success:** Strong interpersonal skills increase efficiency, foster teamwork, and help in conflict resolution.
- **Relationship Building:** It is the foundation for connecting, collaborating, and understanding each other, shaping personal and professional relationships.
- **Personal Growth:** Developing these skills leads to better career prospects and helps create positive environments.